Priority Whiplash



THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Find out what is really needed, show what would have to wait, and get a decision everyone can work from.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

One more thing. And it is urgent.

Another request lands, and the team's week is already full. Let's find out what's needed and look at the work people are waiting for. Then we can see what fits and what might need to wait.

Find out what is needed

A request to show a customer a new screen could mean a sketch, a clickable demonstration, or working software. Ask before treating those as the same amount of work.

Check whether it fits

List the work already promised and ask the team what the new request would take. Include support, testing, and review. Sometimes it fits. If it doesn't, something needs to change.

Make a recommendation

Could you do a smaller version? Put something else off? Use work you already have? Describe the choices and explain which you recommend.

Get a clear answer

If you're allowed to make the call, make it and tell the people affected. If it changes commitments someone else owns, take the recommendation to them. Record what is decided.

Start by getting the current work and the new request in one place. That gives you something concrete to talk through with the team.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

You can be frustrated and still be curious.

A new urgent request can feel like nobody remembers the promises you're already trying to keep. That feeling is worth noticing before you write the reply.

What actually happened?

Start with what was said or done. "They asked for Friday" tells us what happened. "They don't care about the team" is an explanation you may have added. What could you ask to find out what's behind the request?

Why do you care?

Who would be better off if this worked? Perhaps a customer could stop chasing an answer, or your team could finish something it promised. Say why that matters to you, and ask what matters to the other person too.

What would better look like?

Imagine the next few weeks going well. What would people be doing differently? Describe that in ordinary words, then ask the other person what they would add or change.

Keep these notes to yourself

These questions are for your own thinking; you can answer them without typing. If you use the Lab's private notes, they stay only in the open tab. They aren't saved or exported, and disappear when you refresh or leave.

An opening you can adapt: "I want us to find a way through this. Can we look at what is happening and work out what to do next?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Find out what Friday is really for.

“We need a demo” can mean several different things. A few questions now can spare people a week of work on the wrong answer.

Ask what they need to learn

What will the customer decide after seeing it? Are they choosing between ideas, checking a workflow, or expecting working software?

Ask what would be enough

Would sketches let them respond? Do they need to click through the screens? What would a working version tell them that a demonstration would not?

Check why now

What is fixed about Friday? Who confirmed it? If the timing is a preference, that may give us another option.

Say why you are asking

I want us to give the customer something useful on Friday. If I understand what they need, I can ask the team what it would take.

Let the answer change your understanding of the work before deciding whether it fits.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What are we already asking people to do?

Use names people recognize. “Fix the broken invitation link” tells us more than “onboarding improvement.”

Start with the people waiting

A new customer can’t join their account. Another customer is waiting for corrected report figures. Describe the work and who needs it.

Include work that is easy to overlook

Customer support, checking changes, meetings, and maintenance all use time. They don’t disappear because they are missing from the feature list.

Describe the new request

Who asked, what do they need, and by when? Find out what they will use it for. In our example, the customer needs to react to a proposed report screen on Friday.

Check the deadline

Ask what confirms the timing. A booked customer meeting is different from a preferred date. Record what you have checked and what you still need to ask.

Try: “What does the customer need to see on Friday? Would the sketches we already have be useful, or do they need to click through it?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What would have to wait?

Let’s check with the people doing the work. If the request won’t fit, what could be smaller, happen later, or wait while this gets done?

Name the work that changes

In the example, a simple demonstration takes two days of team effort. That would mean putting off two days of work correcting a customer's report. Say who needs to know.

Use the time check if it helps

One person-day means one person working for one day. Two people each working for one day add up to two person-days. Compare available time and required work over the same dates. Include review and support.

Understand what the numbers can tell you

Ten days available, ten already needed, and two more requested means the entered plan needs twelve days of effort. The extra two must be addressed. It doesn’t tell you the new finish date; ask the team about skills, waiting, and the order of work.

Keep another option open

Perhaps the existing sketches would do. Perhaps the demonstration can wait. Protect essential checks and customer promises, and explain the consequences of each choice.

Changing the written recommendation doesn’t change the calculator. Its numbers describe the work you entered before the proposed change.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Make the choice visible without making it a threat.

You are helping people choose how to use the time available. The work already promised and the new opportunity both deserve a fair hearing.

1 / Check the whole week

Are support, review, meetings, and fixes included? Are these the right people and the same dates? Ask the team to correct the list.

2 / Name who would wait

Which customer or colleague would lose something if we changed the plan? What have we told them, and who can discuss a different date with them?

3 / Keep a smaller option

Could sketches answer Friday's question? Could part of the demonstration wait? Explain what each option would help the customer decide.

4 / Check the result together

Ten days available and twelve needed exposes a gap. It does not tell us which work to delay or what a new finish date should be.

Try: "Here are two ways we could help on Friday. Can we look at what each means for the people already waiting?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What do you think we should do?

You have looked at what would change. Which option would you recommend, and why? That gives the person making the call a useful place to start.

Make the choice specific

“Prepare the small demonstration and postpone the report correction” is a choice. “Be more flexible” isn’t enough for anyone to act on.

Explain who benefits and who waits

The customer in Friday's meeting can react to the idea. The customer waiting for correct report figures waits longer. Both belong in the conversation.

Find the person who can make the call

Use a real name. Who can approve changing these customer commitments? If that is you, decide within your authority and communicate the change.

Say when an answer is needed

In the example, Wednesday afternoon gives the team time to change the plan and tell the account manager by Thursday morning.

Try: “I recommend the small demonstration, with the report correction moved back. We need a decision by Wednesday so we can tell the people affected.”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Get the right people into the decision.

A request from someone senior can still need a decision from the person who owns the commitments it would change.

Who brings the recommendation?

The PM gathers the team's estimates and the customer needs. Include what the requester has told you and what the affected customer is waiting for.

Who must be heard?

Ask the people building and checking the work, the requester, and the person responsible for the delayed customer promise. Record any unanswered questions.

Who can make the call?

Name the person allowed to reorder these commitments. Check their authority and the required approvals instead of assuming the loudest request decides it.

When do we need the answer?

Leave time to change the plan and tell people. If no answer comes, follow the existing agreed plan within your authority and ask when a decision can be made.

A recommendation can be accepted, changed, or declined. Record the answer people actually give.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Keep bringing it back to the actual work.

People may see a consequence you have missed. Listen, check the facts, and adjust the recommendation where needed.

“They are all top priority”

“Which should the team work on first? If the new request goes first, are we agreeing that the report correction waits?”

“It is only a day or two”

“Does that include checking and testing it? Let’s ask the people doing the work before we promise.”

“Nothing can move”

“Could we make the demonstration smaller, use the existing sketches, or change the date?” If none works, record the unresolved decision rather than silently assuming overtime.

“This is an emergency”

Follow the incident process if it is a real emergency. Name who can authorize the interruption, which work pauses, and when the temporary arrangement will be reviewed.

Try: “I can see why Friday matters. Here is what we could do, and what would have to wait. Can we choose a plan together?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Make sure “wait” really means wait.

A written tradeoff achieves little if the team is still expected to do both pieces of work. Check what the decision means in practice.

For the person deciding

Explain what the demonstration helps the customer do, which work would wait, and the alternative. Ask for a response by the time the team needs it.

For the team

After agreement, name the work to start and the work to pause. Ask whether anyone has received conflicting instructions or is still being measured against the old plan.

For the customer who waits

Ask the account manager to explain the change and confirm the revised date after the team checks it. Don’t calculate that date by adding the effort gap to the calendar.

After Friday

Did the demonstration answer the customer’s question? Did the report correction actually wait? If people did both in overtime, bring that back into the next conversation.

Use the Lab’s final step to prepare the updates and record what happened when the plan met the real week.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A Friday demonstration meets a full week.

Fictional example: the team is fixing a broken account invitation, checking customer-data security, and correcting inaccurate report totals. The sales director now wants a demonstration for Friday.

What is already promised

New customers need the invitation fix. The next software update needs security checks. An existing customer needs corrected report figures. Support and review are included in the team's estimate of ten days of work.

What the new request means

The customer wants to react to a proposed report screen. A simple clickable demonstration would take two more days. The team has ten days of work time between them before Friday, and all ten are already needed.

The recommendation

Make a simple clickable demonstration and put off two days of work on the incorrect report totals. Check the new report-fix date with the team before promising it.

The decision and follow-up

In this example, the product director agrees on Wednesday to postpone the report correction. The team checks its new finish date. The product manager updates the plan; the account manager tells the affected customer. They review what happened after Friday's meeting. The Lab example starts before the decision.

If the new work had fitted, there would have been no need to invent a tradeoff. Here it doesn’t fit, so the people involved make a clear choice.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

From a new request to a clear answer.

Bring one new request and the work it competes with. You can prepare alone, then check your assumptions with the team.

Current work

List the current commitments, the new request, and why it matters now. Preview Current Work List if you want someone to check it.

What changes

Check the time available if useful. Write what would wait, who would be affected, and another option. Preview What Would Change to review the consequences.

Recommend

Write your recommendation, name the person who can decide, and say when you need an answer.

Record

Keep the status as PROPOSAL before the conversation and leave the actual decision blank. Preview Priority Decision Brief. After the conversation, record the response, update who will do what, and rebuild the brief.

Copy, download, or print the brief to take into your usual work tools. The Lab doesn’t send it or change the team's plan. Use Load Examples to see fictional answers for the current step. You’ll be asked before existing answers are replaced.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What happened after the conversation?

Once you have talked, come back and see what changed. What helped, what still needs attention, and who needs to hear from you?

Follow up

Check that people followed the agreed choice. Did the postponed work actually wait, or did the team end up doing both? Were the affected customers told? Use what happened to improve the next decision.

Try saying it out loud

Read your message aloud. Does it sound like you? If a phrase feels awkward, use the words you'd say in the meeting. Someone you trust can help you spot anything that's hard to follow.

Keep the record

Copy, download, or print anything you need to keep. Shared answers save in this browser on this device; they don't follow you to another device. Private notes aren't saved. Export before clearing a draft or browser data.

Check what happened

Was the decision understood? Did someone act? Did the change help the people it was meant to help? If nobody responded, find out who can decide and agree when to ask again. Silence doesn't mean yes.

You don't have to fix the whole organization in one conversation. Leave knowing what happens next, who will do it, and when you'll check back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What did this week teach the team?

Repeated urgent requests shape more than a work list. Notice the habits people learn from how each request is handled.

Identity

Can someone be dependable without saying yes to everything? What did this decision teach people about using their judgment?

Relationship

Did the requester and the team understand each other better? Were the people whose work moved treated with care?

Vision

Did a clear customer need help you choose, or did the most recent request simply win? What worthwhile result are you protecting?

Culture

Can people point to work that was genuinely paused? If everything stays urgent, what needs to change in how requests enter the team's week?

Notice the pattern across several weeks, not just one request. You can think about the effects on people without recording personal information.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

1 / Another urgent request

The team is fixing broken account invitations, checking customer-data access, and correcting a report. Sales now asks for a demonstration on Friday. The PM first asks what the customer needs from the meeting.

PM

“What do they need to decide on Friday? Do they need the report to work, or to see how the screen might work?”

Sales director

“They want to see the idea and tell us what they think. It doesn’t have to work yet.”

Ask yourself: What does the request mean in actual work, now that you have asked?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

2 / Look at the time

The fictional estimates are ten person-days available, ten already needed, and two for a clickable demonstration. The plan would need twelve. Those figures include support and review; they do not predict a finish date.

Engineering lead

“A clickable demo would take us about two days. We can fit it in if the report fix waits.”

PM

“Let’s also keep the existing sketches as an option. The report customer is waiting for accurate figures.”

Ask yourself: Do the figures cover the same people, dates, and necessary checks?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

3 / Bring two choices

The PM recommends a small clickable demonstration only if the product director agrees to postpone the report correction. The alternative is to use the sketches and keep all current work. The decision is still open.

PM

“I’d do the clickable demo if we can delay the report fix. Otherwise, let’s use the sketches. Could you let us know by Wednesday afternoon?”

Product director

“What would we tell the customer waiting for the corrected report?”

Ask yourself: Have you made the cost to the other customer as clear as the benefit to Friday’s customer?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

4 / Record what was chosen

In this fictional continuation, the director approves the smaller demonstration and the delay. The team checks the report date. The PM updates the plan, and the account manager tells the affected customer.

Product director

“Let’s do the small demo and put the report fix on hold. Keep going with the invitation fix and security checks.”

PM

“I’ll get the report date checked and make sure the account manager can explain the change.”

Ask yourself: Who needs a different instruction now that the decision is made?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

See how it could unfold.

5 / See what actually happened

This example ends with a check, not a victory lap. The group asks whether the demonstration helped, the delayed customer was told, and the team actually stopped the postponed work.

PM

“Did Friday help the customer decide anything? And did the report work really wait?”

Engineering lead

“Yes. We paused it. Let’s ask what the meeting is for earlier next time.”

Ask yourself: What small change would make the next urgent request easier to handle?

Open this part of your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

Your Company's God is Showing

Nic Payne · Article

Use Nic's essay to examine what repeated urgency says about what matters in the organization.

What does the team see us protect when we are under pressure?

Take this into your Lab >

[C]ulture → [V]ulture

Nic Payne · Article

Look at what living with the current pace does to a person over time.

Who keeps absorbing the work that never fits?

Take this into your Lab >

Leadership as bowl, water, and current

Nic Payne · Video · start at 4:19

Consider the space you make for the requester and the people already carrying the work.

Whose experience has not been heard in this decision?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

[You Have a Culture Problem]

Nic Payne · Article

Trace how repeated choices about urgent work become expectations and habits.

What are we teaching people to expect the next time someone asks?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[When Mattering Isn't Enough]

Nic Payne · Article

Nic asks what happens beyond feeling valued. Consider whether the way work is assigned gives people room to grow.

What cost to people is missing from our work list?

[Take this into your Lab >]

[Work in process limits]

DORA / Google Cloud · Research-informed practice guide

Use this guide to discuss how much work to start and how to include tasks that are easy to overlook.

What could we finish sooner if we stopped starting so many things?

[Take this into your Lab >]

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

A little more help.

Shape Up — Chapter 3: Set Boundaries

Ryan Singer · Book chapter

Explore a smaller useful answer within the time available.

What could Friday's customer learn from something smaller?

Take this into your Lab >

RAPID® Decision Making

Bain & Company · Originator's framework explanation

Check who advises on the choice and who can change the commitments involved.

Who can decide which customer promise waits?

Take this into your Lab >

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

The thinking behind the tool.

Holistic Shaping asks what work is doing to people, as well as what people are doing at work. These short notes connect the Guide to Nic's teaching and a few practical sources. Read what helps with the situation in front of you. Links open the original resources.

Back in the Guide

CHAPTER 02

The new request is somebody's problem, too.

Ask what the customer meeting needs to accomplish. A request that sounds careless from your side may carry a commitment you have not heard about. Understanding that does not erase the team's existing work. It gives you something real to work out together.

Worth asking: What do they need to happen, and what have they not heard about your situation?

ChapGPT schools me on leading well
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 03

Include the work nobody put on the list.

DORA's guide to work in process limits includes support and maintenance alongside planned work. Use that reminder when listing commitments. Starting more work can leave everything waiting; a full calendar alone does not tell you what the team can finish.

Worth asking: What keeps interrupting the team but never appears in the plan?

Work in process limits
DORA / Google Cloud · Research-informed practice guide

CHAPTER 04

Who pays for the extra work?

"Does our pace grow or shrink people?"

Nic Payne · Your Company's God is Showing

Look at the cost to people as well as the work. If the demo only fits because someone gives up evenings, swallows a concern, or loses the time they needed to learn, put that into the discussion. Ask the people affected. The cost does not disappear because the plan leaves it out.

Worth asking: What would need to change for the team to do this without quietly paying for it themselves?

Your Company's God is Showing
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 05

The calculator cannot make the choice for you.

Ten days of work plus two more days will not fit into ten available days. That helps reveal the conflict. It cannot decide whose promise matters most, whether the work is ready to start, or what repeated interruptions do to trust and concentration. Bring those questions into the decision.

Worth asking: What matters here that the numbers do not show?

The Search For Unapologetic Impracticality In Leadership: Part III - How We Trained Ourselves to Mistake Certainty for Wisdom
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 09

What are these repeated emergencies teaching people?

If the loudest request always wins, people may learn that careful planning and honest commitments count for little. Cultural Orbital Mechanics asks how that experience shapes relationships, identity, and the future people can imagine together. Try one agreed way to consider new work, then see what changes.

Worth asking: Can people now raise a conflict early and take part in deciding what happens?

You Have a Culture Problem
Nic Payne · Article

Why Work Can't Be Your Church
Nic Payne · Article

Kill the Ghost Goal
Nic Payne / Rebel Leaders · Codex practice

Explore more of Nic's Holistic Shaping work at Rebel Leaders.

The notes apply the teaching to these situations. They are not quotations unless marked. The health reflection is optional; you do not need to record or share personal information.